Babur had impeccable lineage. He was a direct descendant of Ghengis Khan from his mother's side and from Taimur the Lame on his father's side. However, Taimur's empire had disintegrated by the time Babur was born. At the age of twelve, he inherited a tiny kingdom in the beautiful Ferghana valley in Central Asia. Babur tells us that it could barely support an army of three to four thousand men. [23] This did not deter him from repeatedly trying to capture Taimur's capital of Samarkand. He even succeeded briefly, but could not hold on to it. Eventually, the Uzbeks chased him out and he made his way south with a tiny band of followers. Ever the adventurer, he won and lost many battles along the way till he gained control of Kabul. It was then that he saw the opportunity of making a raid into India.

It was an audacious plan because his army was much smaller than the Sultan's, but Babur had a secret weapon—matchlock guns. This was the first time that guns would be used in North India. (South India had already tasted Portuguese artillery a few decades earlier.) Babur decisively defeated the Sultan and quickly went on to beat off all other rivals, including the Rajputs. Thus was born the Mughal (i.e. Mongol) empire in India. Note that the dynasty did not use this term to describe itself. Rather, the Mughals preferred to call themselves 'Gurkhani'. This is after the title of 'Gurkhan' meaning 'son-in-law' that Taimur liked to use after he was married to a princess from Ghengiz Khan's dynasty.

Although Babur had finally conquered a significant kingdom, he always hankered for Samarkand. His opinion of India is rather unflattering: 'Hindustan is a place of little charm. There is no beauty in its people, no graceful social intercourse, no poetic talent or understanding, no etiquette, nobility or manliness. The arts and crafts have no harmony or symmetry. There are no good horses, meat, grapes, melons, or other fruit. There is no ice, cold water, good food or bread in the markets'. At least, Babur was very candid about why he was in India: 'The one nice aspect of Hindustan is that it is a large country with lots of gold and money'. [24]

Babur died less than five years after he came to India. His empire was inherited by his son Humayun, who started construction on the next Delhi